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Causes of Populism: How Mobilization meets Opportunity

Thesis:

Populism is the term which dominates the current paradigm of modern political discourse; by reshaping party politics, public forums, and challenging liberal democratic norms across the globe. The unique emergence of populist politics across regions makes clear common structural pillars which exasperate populism's visible rise. In this essay I will analyze the main causes of populism internationally through relevant academic literature, which establishes populism in what I view as two dimensions: mobilization, and political opportunity. Key cornerstones of the causes of populism and the root of its negative effects.

Defining Populism:

Populism has a wide range of definitions and identified features, however most scholars agree on its shared core (and why populism is hard to differentiate from different ideologies), as defined by Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) as a "thin-centered ideology" which divides society into to opposing groups of the "pure people" and the "corrupt elite". Due to this ambiguity populism can attach itself to a myriad of host ideologies, enabling it to flourish across diverse political environments. By criticizing existing power structures, and a perceived betrayal of the interest of the pure citizens by the corrupt establishment elite, populists propose that only a direct, unmediated relationship between a populist leader and the people can restore power to the

people, thus a true “direct” democratic system. This is the double-edged sword of populism, demanding change to the democratic system through a positive representative appeal followed by a dangerous appeal to centralized power. By simplifying politics through the lens of conflict, delegitimizing pluralism (the effect of dissenting voices in politics), political compromise, and institutional safeguards; creating a dangerous breeding ground for anti-democratic demagogues.

As Political Mobilization (demand):

Political mobilization in relevant literature is usually marked as “demand-side” causes of populism, boiling down to the peoples demand for representation for their grievances, this is a feature in any perfect democracy, however party politics and other factors push popular policies to the wayside. This focus on social, economic, and cultural grievances/fears makes voters receptive to populist rhetoric. Berman (2021) argues that in the case of western democracies, long-term structural changes; through the likes of: economic stagnation, rising inequality, deindustrialization, and cultural polarization being left unaddressed by mainstream parties die to the complexity of these issues. Due to party and “big-tent” politics apparent in the US two-party system and European parliamentary systems, unable to address thorny social problems due to the broad nature of parties and coalitions seeking to maintain the power of their “sect” instead of the system in its whole (institutions and all). This disconnect causes many voters to feel politically unheard, alienated, and betrayed. Populist movements and leaders capitalize on these sentiments by presenting themselves as a true representative bastion of “the people” (*vox populi*). This perception of traditional political channels no longer functioning effectively is shown by Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) as a growing gap between citizens and political elites which populists can use to promise a restore popular sovereignty, by claiming that elites (politicians, bureaucrats, media, and cultural elites) ignore the lived experiences of ordinary citizens. Populist intertwining

economic grievances and cultural grievances creating a fearmongering around economic wellbeing and rapid social change causes massive disruption in the political climate and discontent among people. These real or perceived grievances do not automatically generate populist leaders or their sentiment, but they heighten receptiveness to leaders who articulate them in simple, emotional resonant terms, even offering drastic yet seemingly simple solutions. Berman (2021) highlights that populism thrives when mainstream parties "drop the ball" by maintaining rigid ideological positions or fail to adapt to shifting voter priorities. When establishment parties converge around the political center or adopt technocratic (bureaucratic, service centered) policy styles, large segments of a voter base can feel abandoned. Populism therefore emerges as a demand response to unaddressed anxieties and unmet expectations of the voting populace.

As Political Opportunity (supply):

While unaddressed grievances provide fertile ground, populism further requires political entrepreneurs (opportunists) who can articulate and channel discontent into a cohesive movement. This "supply-side" theory focuses on institutional contexts, in party systems and leadership strategies which gives rise to populists. By this Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) argue that populist leaders are often opportunists who strategically adopt populist rhetoric to differentiate themselves from an unpopular establishment. These leaders frame themselves as strong decisive outsiders (though most are insider-outsiders) who alone can challenge entrenched, troubled elites and protect the "pure people". Berman (2021) adds that the through the inaction of parties and weakening of institutions, create openings for charismatic strongmen. Modern leaders can bypass political and party structures and communicate directly with citizens through digital media, enabling personalized leader-centric movements, through this perceived

parasocial relationship with strongman leaders. This opportunity structure not only empowers political actors but also undermines collective decision-making (pluralism), causing political systems to be vulnerable to "cannibalistic" appeals. Political systems with high fragmentation, weak parties, or poorly functioning electoral institutions are more susceptible to populists. In proportional systems with many small parties, populists can enter the political arena and its discourse with relatively low vote threshold. Opposed, in majoritarian (mainly, presidential) systems, populists emerge when established parties collapse or become internally divided. The supply-side perspective also emphasizes the importance of events and crises in the emergence of populists; as economic recessions, corruption scandals, migration surges, and the like create opportunities for leaders who promise radical change as a path to prosperous normalcy. Crucially, demand-side effects can only take hold in a system meaningfully if the people are met with a supply-side solution in the form of populist leader or policy, populist can spur or notice a demand by the disillusioned public to grievances to which a populist leader can take advantage of establishment inaction by portraying themselves as capable of rescuing the nation from corrupt elites and their bureaucratic policies.

Causes as Factors in Populism's Effects:

The causes of populism directly shape its future consequences. Because populism is rooted in grievance mobilization and opportunistic leadership, it often produces political outcomes which further destabilize democratic norms of which populist are sceptical, as they serve the "corrupt elite".

First, the moralized division between "the people" and "the elite" encourages intolerance toward political opposition. If opponents are not merely wrong but corrupt or anti-

national, compromise is out of the question for populists. This dynamic weakens democratic pluralism and can undermine the rule of law (Mudde & Kaltwasser, 2017).

Second, opportunistic leaders frequently introduce policies that concentrate executive powers, thus individual populist leaders. Since their legitimacy stems from direct claims to represent the will of the people, they often attack courts, the media, or independent institutions as obstacles to popular rule (Berman, 2021). In extreme cases, these attacks can slide toward authoritarianism.

Third, the underlying grievances that fuel populism remain unresolved. Populists may win elections by promising simple solutions to complex problems, but once in power they often fail to deliver sustainable improvements.

Their tendency to politicize institutions and polarize society can worsen the crises that enabled their rise in the first place. Thus, the causes of populism are not merely conditions of an aggrieved political climate; they also reveal why populism can frequently generate negative political consequences upon institutions .

Conclusion:

Populism emerges as an interaction of (real or perceived) societal grievances and strategic political leadership. From demand driven by economic hardship, cultural tension, and declining trust in institutions create a force of discontent. While political opportunists respond to this demand by supplying leadership and solutions to these sentiments, whether real or spurred by a constructed conflict between “the people” and the “corrupt elite”. As Mudde and Kaltwasser (2017) as well as Berman (2021) propose: populism is not simply an expression of public discontent, or merely the product of charismatic leaders; it is the synergy of both forces operating

within the framework of supply and demand within various institutional contexts. Understanding these causes is essential not only for recognizing the risk that they may pose to democratic governance but also in correctively interpreting the modern paradigm of political discourse. In a democratic system grievances will persist, and political systems will weaken and strengthen to enable opportunist politicians, populism will remain a powerful, yet cautionary force, within past and present contemporary politics.

Works Cited

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